‘That’s not right, sir. Anyway, how many casualties are we ready to take?’ I asked brusquely.

In actual war or combat one takes many calculated risks. It’s the done thing. If we lose lives while doing so, that is understandable. However, in this situation during peacetime, I was convinced that playing around with the lives of our officers and men would be nothing short of being foolhardy, and thus not justified. Even the local Mishmi guides from that area refused to be coaxed or bribed into making an attempt to cross the waters. The chief umpire, Brigadier Malhotra, was really having a tough time. On an impulse, Brigadier Malhotra took the handset from me and said, ‘Ved, the battalion commander is damn right, the nullah is in spate and it is next to impossible to cross it in this state.’

There was an ominous silence and then there was no answer for quite some time. I think that was enough of a hint for a pragmatic and war-decorated soldier like Brigadier Airy. It was not only a pitch-dark night but the whole area was covered by a thick blanket of fog as well. Till the break of dawn we were moving about like blind men, even when we used pen torches. At one point, as I was trying to go forward to the nullah, I nearly fell off the cliff. Till now I haven’t been able to figure out what made me stop from taking that final step into what appeared like a black hole. Many others in my battalion would have had similar close calls with destiny that night.

After a few hours during which my troops were still trying to get across, it was conveyed to us by the Control HQ that the exercise had been frozen for the next 24 hours. However, as there was no sign of the rain abating, and the fact that all of us, including the umpires, were wet and freezing, it made no sense to keep us dangling in our high-altitude refuges for another day.

As the CO, safeguarding the lives of my men was my fundamental and sacred responsibility. Therefore, I called the Control HQ and told them it would be prudent to call off the exercise, allow the combatants to rest and refit, and then restart the match after two or three days. The chief umpire, who was at the end of his tether, also agreed with me.